attend on their nominal employer. As Burnes tried to explain to the Shah, ‘he might remedy the non-appearance of the British Officers at his Durbar by fixing a day in the week to receive them as they often came and after waiting for a long time departed without an audience’.[77]

But the biggest problem of all, as Macnaghten was frank enough to recognise, was simply the growing taint to Shuja’s reputation brought by his continued association with the infidel British and the spreading conviction that he was merely their puppet. ‘His Majesty labours under peculiar and complicated difficulties,’ Macnaghten wrote to Auckland,

> the foremost of which is his connection with us. We have placed him on his throne, but it will be some time before our motives in doing so are understood and there are many who wilfully misunderstand them. The difference of our religion is of course the chief cause of antipathy on the part of the people. The Afghans are a nation of bigots. Besides an intolerance of our creed, there is an intolerance of our customs and it behoves us therefore to be very wary in our attempts at innovation, nor ought it ever to be forgotten that a system, though excellent in itself, may not be good as applied to this country, nor may it be such as to meet appreciation. It requires the most cautious steering to refrain on the one side from alarming popular prejudices, and on the other from leaving the government in the same imbecile state in which we found it.[78]

To Colvin, Macnaghten developed a similar theme: ‘You rightly conjecture that the Barakzais have the most inflammable material to work upon. Of all moral qualities, avarice, credulity and bigotry are the most inflammable, and the Afghans have all these three in perfection.’ While Macnaghten was correct to point to religious difference as lying at the heart of Afghan objections to the new regime, and to realise that the Muslim ‘ulema were fast establishing themselves as the centre of opposition to Shuja, he was wrong to interpret their objection as mere ‘bigotry’. The mullahs had initially been co-opted by the Anglo-Sadozai regime, which from the beginning paid salaries to those among the ‘ulema who came out in support of the Shah. But the mullahs grew in time to have good reason to dislike a regime which only intermittently patronised their institutions or helped restore their mosques, and which seized for itself many of their *waqf* endowments to help augment the regime’s tax revenues: particular horror was caused when the British ‘went so far as to usurp control of the endowments of the great Sufi shrine of Ashiqan wa Arifan, which had been registered from the days of bygone rulers’. This was an especially tactless move as the shrine, formerly a Buddhist monastery, was Old Kabul’s most important and ancient cult centre, and for several generations had been the